Report card comments for excellent students

Build each comment in four parts: **what the student really does well**, **one real moment** from this report period, **the next challenge**, and **what you or the family will do to help**. Swap [Name] and "their" for the student's name and pronoun, and keep only what is true of this student.

What they do well

Reading

- [Name] reads widely and can explain why an author made a particular choice.
- [Name] backs up their ideas about a text with evidence from the page.

Writing

- [Name] writes with a clear voice and chooses words on purpose.
- [Name] revises their writing carefully, and each draft is stronger than the last.

Math

- [Name] explains their reasoning clearly and can often solve a problem in more than one way.
- [Name] spots patterns and uses them to solve new kinds of problems.

Science

- [Name] plans fair tests and draws conclusions from the evidence.
- [Name] asks questions that can be tested and records results carefully.

Social studies

- [Name] connects events to their causes and uses sources to support an argument.
- [Name] compares different viewpoints and explains why people saw events differently.

Class discussions

- [Name] listens closely in discussions and builds on what others say.
- [Name] asks the questions that move our class discussions forward.

Speaking and presenting

- [Name] speaks clearly to the class and organizes ideas so they are easy to follow.
- [Name] presents with confidence and answers questions thoughtfully.

Works independently

- [Name] starts tasks without prompting and manages their time well.
- [Name] plans longer projects in stages and meets deadlines.

Sticks with hard problems

- [Name] sticks with a hard problem and tries a new approach when the first one doesn't work.
- [Name] treats mistakes as useful information and corrects them carefully.

Careful, accurate work

- [Name] takes care over accuracy and checks their work before handing it in.
- [Name] presents work so clearly that their thinking is easy to follow.

Original ideas

- [Name] brings original ideas to their projects and follows them through.
- [Name] takes creative risks and is willing to try an unusual approach.

Curious beyond the lesson

- [Name] asks thoughtful questions and looks things up to learn more.
- [Name] follows up lessons with their own reading and brings new ideas to class.

Leads group work well

- [Name] leads group work by making sure every voice is heard.
- [Name] shares jobs fairly in group work and keeps the group on track.

Kind and respectful

- [Name] notices when a classmate needs help and offers it kindly.
- [Name] sets a respectful tone in our classroom and treats everyone fairly.

The next challenge

Reading: harder texts, compare authors

- **NEXT** Next quarter, [Name] is ready to read more challenging texts and compare how different authors handle the same idea.
- **YOU** To help with this, I'll offer book choices a step up and ask for evidence in written responses.
- **HOME** At home, you could ask [Name] to recommend a book and explain what the author did well.

Writing: new forms, more risks

- **NEXT** Next quarter, [Name] is ready to try new forms of writing and experiment with structure and voice.
- **YOU** To help with this, I'll set writing tasks with a wider choice of form and audience.
- **HOME** At home, you could read an article or review together and talk about how it was put together.

Math: multi-step, explain why

- **NEXT** Next quarter, [Name] is ready to tackle multi-step problems and explain why a method works as well as how to use it.
- **YOU** To help with this, I'll add problems with more than one route and ask for written explanations.
- **HOME** At home, you could ask [Name] to explain a tricky problem as if teaching it to you.

Math: test and create problems

- **NEXT** Next quarter, [Name] is ready to create their own problems and test whether a method works in every case.
- **YOU** To help with this, I'll set open problems that have no single answer.
- **HOME** At home, you could look for math in everyday life, such as comparing prices or planning a journey.

Science: own investigation

- **NEXT** Next quarter, [Name] is ready to design an investigation from a question of their own.
- **YOU** To help with this, I'll make time for a small independent investigation.
- **HOME** At home, you could try a simple kitchen experiment and predict what will happen first.

Research a question of their own

- **NEXT** Next quarter, [Name] is ready to take on a longer research project on a question of their own choosing.
- **YOU** To help with this, I'll work with [Name] to narrow the question and find reliable sources.
- **HOME** At home, you could visit the library together and follow up one thing [Name] wants to know more about.

Go deeper, not faster

- **NEXT** Next quarter, [Name] is ready to go deeper when work is finished early, adding reasoning, detail or a second solution.
- **YOU** To help with this, I'll have an extension task ready that asks for depth as well as speed.
- **HOME** At home, you could ask "how do you know?" and "is there another way?" about something [Name] has finished.

Use feedback on strong work

- **NEXT** Next quarter, [Name] is ready to use feedback to make strong work even better.
- **YOU** To help with this, I'll give one specific target on each longer piece of work.
- **HOME** At home, you could ask [Name] which piece of work is strongest and what would make it better.

Try things that might not work

- **NEXT** Next quarter, [Name] is ready to take on challenges where success isn't guaranteed and see a first attempt as a starting point.
- **YOU** To help with this, I'll set some tasks that are meant to take more than one try.
- **HOME** At home, you could talk about something you found hard and how you kept going.

Share ideas more often

- **NEXT** Next quarter, [Name] is ready to share their ideas more often in whole-class discussions.
- **YOU** To help with this, I'll give advance notice of some questions and invite [Name] to go first.
- **HOME** At home, you could ask [Name] what their opinion is on something in the news or a book.

Draw others into discussions

- **NEXT** Next quarter, [Name] is ready to draw classmates into discussions by asking questions as well as giving answers.
- **YOU** To help with this, I'll use roles in discussions so that everyone has a turn to lead.
- **HOME** At home, you could take turns around the table, with each person asking the next a question.

Lead a project

- **NEXT** Next quarter, [Name] is ready to lead a group project, including sharing out the jobs and the credit.
- **YOU** To help with this, I'll offer a chance to lead a small team on our next project.
- **HOME** At home, you could let [Name] plan and run something at home, such as a meal or a family outing.

Plan and set own deadlines

- **NEXT** Next quarter, [Name] is ready to plan longer projects independently and set their own deadlines.
- **YOU** To help with this, I'll step back on the next project and check in at the halfway point.
- **HOME** At home, you could use a calendar together to break one big job into smaller steps.

Explain thinking in more detail

- **NEXT** Next quarter, [Name] is ready to write down the reasoning behind their answers as well as the answers themselves.
- **YOU** To help with this, I'll ask for a short explanation alongside the answer.
- **HOME** At home, you could ask [Name] to talk you through how a piece of homework was done.

50 short comments

1. [Name] explains their thinking clearly and listens well to others.
2. [Name] reads widely and talks thoughtfully about books.
3. [Name] writes with real care and revises each draft.
4. [Name] solves problems in more than one way and explains each one.
5. [Name] backs up every answer with clear reasoning.
6. [Name] asks excellent questions that help the whole class think.
7. [Name] plans their work well and meets every deadline.
8. [Name] checks their work carefully and fixes their own mistakes.
9. [Name] sticks with hard problems and tries new approaches.
10. [Name] starts work promptly and stays focused to the end.
11. [Name] brings original ideas and follows them through.
12. [Name] takes creative risks and learns from each attempt.
13. [Name] leads group work fairly and listens to every voice.
14. [Name] is kind to classmates and respectful to everyone.
15. [Name] uses feedback well and each piece of work improves.
16. [Name] learns new ideas quickly and applies them with care.
17. [Name] uses evidence well in written and spoken work.
18. [Name] speaks clearly and confidently in front of the class.
19. [Name] follows their curiosity well beyond the lesson.
20. [Name] shows strong understanding across every subject this quarter.
21. [Name] has made excellent progress in reading this quarter.
22. [Name] has made excellent progress in writing this quarter.
23. [Name] has made excellent progress in math this quarter.
24. [Name] has mastered this quarter's math and explains it well.
25. [Name] applies math skills confidently to new problems.
26. [Name] writes clear, well-organized paragraphs with strong detail.
27. [Name] reads fluently and understands complex texts.
28. [Name] draws sensible conclusions from science investigations.
29. [Name] connects new learning to earlier lessons.
30. [Name] contributes thoughtful ideas to every class discussion.
31. [Name] works well alone and as part of a team.
32. [Name] takes responsibility for their own learning.
33. [Name] sets high standards and works steadily to meet them.
34. [Name] prepares thoroughly and comes to class ready to learn.
35. [Name] keeps going calmly when work gets difficult.
36. [Name] takes pride in their work and it shows.
37. [Name] helps set a positive, focused tone in our class.
38. [Name] shares ideas generously and credits others.
39. [Name] is ready for more challenging texts next quarter.
40. [Name] is ready for multi-step problems next quarter.
41. [Name] is ready to lead a group project next quarter.
42. [Name] is ready to design their own investigation next quarter.
43. [Name] is ready to take on a longer research project.
44. [Name] is ready to try harder problems with more than one route.
45. [Name] is ready to explain their reasoning in more detail.
46. [Name] is ready to experiment with new forms of writing.
47. [Name] is ready to share ideas more often in discussions.
48. [Name] is ready to go deeper when work is finished early.
49. [Name] has had an outstanding quarter: focused, thoughtful and curious.
50. [Name] has had an excellent quarter and is ready for greater depth.

Phrases to avoid, rewritten

Instead of	Write
A pleasure to have in class.	[Name] comes to class ready to work and asks the questions that move our discussions forward.
A joy to teach.	[Name] listens closely in discussions and builds on what others say, which makes our lessons better.
Keep up the good work!	Next quarter, [Name] is ready to tackle multi-step problems and explain why a method works.
An excellent student.	[Name] plans longer projects in stages, checks the details and meets deadlines.
A model student.	[Name] starts tasks without prompting, manages time well and sets a respectful tone in our classroom.
Is very bright.	[Name] explains ideas clearly and enjoys working on questions with more than one answer.
Is gifted in math.	[Name] spots patterns and uses them to solve new kinds of problems.
Is a natural at writing.	[Name] chooses words on purpose and revises each draft carefully.
Is so smart!	[Name] connects new ideas to earlier learning and explains the link clearly.
Is the top student in the class.	[Name] has met every standard this quarter, and is ready for harder texts and longer projects.
Is far ahead of the rest of the class.	[Name] understands this quarter's work securely, so we are moving on to problems that need more reasoning.
Is smarter than most students.	[Name] picks up new ideas quickly and applies them carefully in unfamiliar problems.
Finishes first every time.	[Name] works efficiently, and is now learning to use extra time to add depth and reasoning.
Helps the weaker students finish their work.	[Name] explains ideas to classmates patiently when they ask, and has a challenge of their own to work on too.
My little helper.	[Name] notices what needs doing and offers to help without being asked.
Does everything perfectly.	[Name] takes great care over accuracy, and next quarter is ready to try tasks that take more than one attempt.
There is nothing to improve.	[Name] is working securely at this level. Next quarter, the challenge is a longer research project on a question of their own.
Straight A's again.	[Name]'s grades reflect careful planning, thorough checking and good use of feedback.
Has great potential.	[Name] writes clearly and uses evidence well, and is ready to try longer pieces of writing next.
Will go far.	[Name] sets high standards, uses feedback well and is ready for more independent work next quarter.
Is bored in class.	[Name] understands the work quickly, so I am adding extension tasks that ask for depth.
Well behaved and no trouble.	[Name] treats classmates with respect and listens carefully to their ideas.
Works hard.	[Name] plans ahead, asks for feedback and uses it to improve the next draft.
Excels in all areas.	[Name] has made strong progress in reading, writing and math this quarter, and is especially strong at explaining reasoning.

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